simultaneously positioned Yogi Adityanath as the inheritor of a religio-political tradition going back several decades, and as the one who heralded the transformation of the holy city from a 'sooni-see [sad] Ayodhya' to 'sundar [beautiful] Ayodhya'. The state TV anchor then went on to say that this was not just 'Ram's Ayodhya' on Diwali, but a metaphor for '*satta mei Ram*: *chaahe Dilli mein ya Lucknow mein*' (Ram in power, whether in Delhi or in Lucknow). 'Nature chooses its best sons,' said the DD anchor. He concluded that it was up to today's 'adhunik Ram' (modern Rams) to decide the future direction of India, and praised Narendra Modi and Yogi Adityanath for 'redefining India'.[27]

In fact, the Modi government's ₹971-crore[28] Central Vista redevelopment plan, an overhaul of New Delhi's imperial heart, is a physical manifestation of this redefinition as well as of Modi's 'New India'. The plan envisages a new Parliament building, the redevelopment of the 3-kilometre-long ceremonial avenue linking the Rashtrapati Bhawan and the iconic India Gate, new residences for the prime minister and vice president, and new office blocks for fifty-one Union government ministries. A number of conservationists, architects and urban planners have opposed it and called it 'vulgar'.[29] When activists went to court against construction work at the Central Vista during the pandemic, the Delhi High Court, on 31 May 2021, dismissed their petition as 'motivated', declared the plan an 'essential project of national importance' and imposed a ₹1 lakh fine on the petitioners. A three-judge bench of the Supreme Court upheld this verdict on 29 June 2021. The apex court said 'no interference is required' because the Central Vista project had 'complied of all protocols'. It also observed that the petitioners were selective in choosing the Central Vista project alone and did not research about such similar public projects where construction was ongoing.[30]

The Central Vista's principal architect, Bimal Patel, initially countered heritage concerns with a utilitarian argument about the administrative and practical needs of a changing and dynamic capital city,[31] while the government argued for the project in epochal terms. He emphasised that while the colonial British built Delhi's most